



SOUTHERN LATITUDES

Orion is high in the sky, and his head points down to the northern horizon while his feet are tipped toward the southern horizon. The three stars that form his belt are overhead. The sword hanging from the belt is identified by stars and a bright nebula, the Orion Nebula (M42), which is the brightest and best-known nebula. Sharp-eyed observers will see it as a milky

Sirius and M41

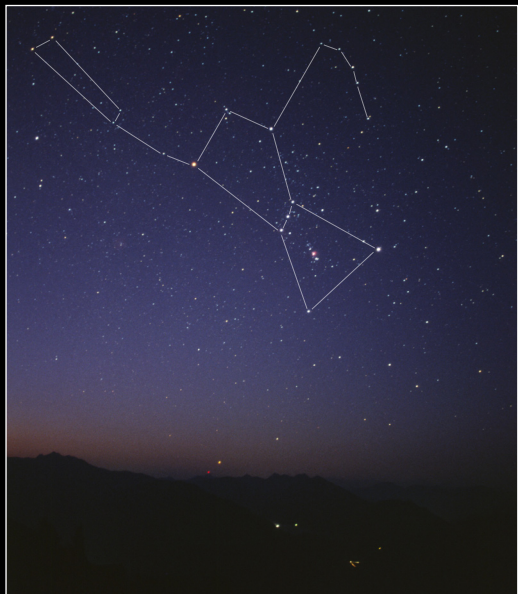
Sirius (top center) is the brightest star of all. Its brightness (magnitude -1.44) can be explained in part by its relative closeness; it is just 8.6 light-years away. By contrast, the open star cluster M41 (bottom center) is about 2,300 light-years away. In good conditions, it can be seen with the naked eye.

patch, and binoculars will confirm its position. Close to M42 but closer to the belt is NGC 1981—a scattered open star cluster that must be viewed through binoculars.

Auriga and its bright star Capella lie between Orion and the northern horizon. Procyon, the bright star of Canis Minor, is to the east of Betelgeuse, the star that marks one of the hunter's shoulders. To the east of Orion's feet is Sirius, the bright star that marks the head of the second of Orion's dogs. To the northwest and below Orion is Taurus; and to the lower right of Orion, beyond his club-holding hand, are the feet of Gemini, the twins. Closer still to the horizon, are the bright stars Castor and Pollux, which mark the twins' heads.

The view looking south is one of contrasts. The eastern—that is, left—part of the sky is full of things to see, but just one bright star shines out in the western portion. This is Achernar, the ninth-brightest star. It marks one end of the meandering constellation Eridanus, which represents the mythological river of that name.

At the left, the Milky Way flows from the southeastern horizon and up into the sky toward Sirius. En route it crosses the rich starfields of Centaurus, Crux, and Carina. Centaurus, the centaur, is lying with its back almost against the horizon. Between its upward-pointing legs is Crux, the smallest constellation of all.



Orion, the hunter

One of the most easily recognized constellations in the sky is Orion. Its stars effortlessly draw out the figure of the hunter. Single bright stars mark his shoulders, a small group of stars his head, and a line of three stars his belt. His sword is represented by stars and the star-forming region M42.

